

TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

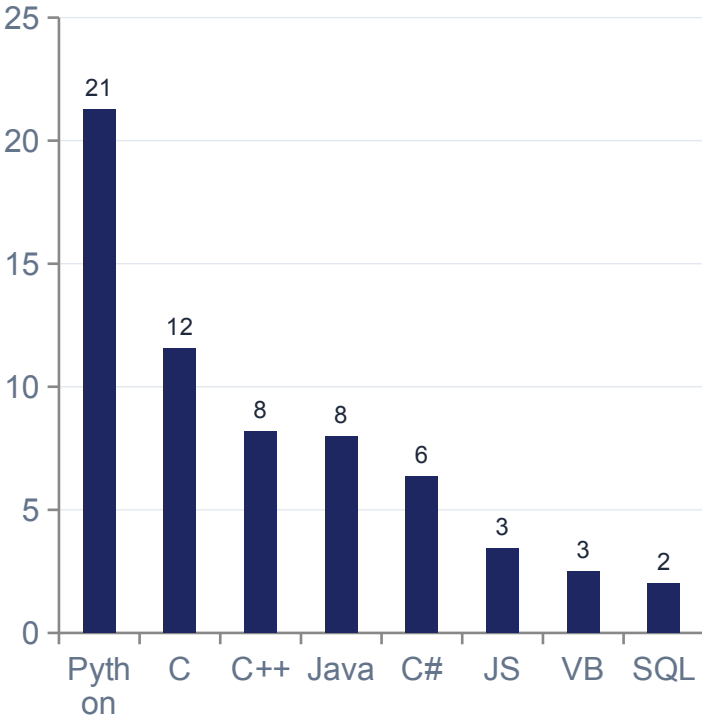
Ratings calculated from search engine hit counts across Google, Bing, Wikipedia, Amazon, and 20+ other sites — reflecting global discussion and demand for programming languages.

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

Top 20 Programming Languages — March 2026

Rank	Prev	Language	Rating	YoY Change
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	2	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	3	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%
11	24	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	17	Assembly language	1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	18	Ada	1.10%	+0.25%

Source: TIOBE Index, March 2026 | Top 4 languages hold 48.97% of total index



Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 — The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

Rank changes from March 2025 to March 2026

Gainers			Losers		
Perl	24 → 11	+13 (+1.05%)	Go	7 → 16	-9 (-1.49%)
R	16 → 9	+7 (+0.94%)	C++	2 → 3	-1 (-2.90%)
Swift	26 → 20	+6 (+0.44%)	Java	3 → 4	-1 (-2.37%)
C	4 → 2	+2 (+2.02%)	PHP	13 → 18	-5 (-0.25%)

Insight: Legacy languages (Perl, R) show surprising resilience, while Go suffers its sharpest decline — possibly displaced by Rust in systems programming.

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Rank positions across four decades (1986–2026)

Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	—	—
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	—	—
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	—	—	—
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	—	—
Go	10	11	60	16	—	—	—	—	—
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2

Python's Meteoric Rise

Unranked before 1991 → #1 by 2026. Peaked above 25% before settling at 21.25%.

Java's Long Decline

Dominated 2005–2018 at 25%+. Now under 8% and falling steadily.

C's Unmatched Resilience

Only language in the top 2 across all nine measurement points since 1986.

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times — More Than Any Other Language

TIOBE 'Programming Language of the Year' winners (largest annual rating gain)

Year	Winner	Year	Winner
2025	C#	2019	C
2024	Python	2018	Python
2023	C#	2016	Go
2022	C++	—	(2017 winner not in source data)
2021	Python	—	
2020	Python	—	

6

Python wins — most of any language

C# won in 2023 & 2025

Reflecting continued growth driven by the .NET ecosystem.

Go won in 2016, now declining

Go's 2016 win preceded its current sharp fall from 7th to 16th.

Note: 2017 winner is not available in the source data.

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

Python's dominance vs. decline trajectory

At 21.25%, Python leads by a wide margin, but its -2.59% YoY drop is the largest among the top 5. Plan for a gradual diversification of your talent pipeline.

C's resurgence signals systems-language demand

C gained +2.02% and climbed from 4th to 2nd. For low-level and embedded projects, C expertise is becoming more critical, not less.

Legacy-language revival (Perl, R, Fortran)

These languages serve entrenched communities in scientific computing and data analysis. Don't write off mature tooling investments.

Go's sharp fall suggests Rust displacement

Go dropped from 7th to 16th (-1.49%). If you're betting on systems programming, evaluate Rust (14th, +0.09%) as a hedge.

Concentration risk in the top 4

Python + C + C++ + Java = 48.97% of the index. Over-reliance on a few languages creates vulnerability if any one declines rapidly.